

Malhar Gudekar

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Hiring Committee

Data Scientist, Student Affairs Analytics and AI
Virginia Tech

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am writing to apply for the Data Scientist position within Virginia Tech's Student Affairs division. As a graduate researcher at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, I spent two years building data pipelines, ML models, and analytics systems in a university research environment, making this role a natural continuation of the work I care about most.

At UIUC's iSchool, I owned end-to-end design and deployment of a cross-platform system that collected and analyzed behavioral and health data from 100+ research participants. I built the ingestion architecture, optimized PostgreSQL data models for a 38% performance improvement, and developed Python-based ML pipelines that improved analytical accuracy by 43%. At UIUC's CHI AI Lab, I built NLP pipelines to process large-scale behavioral datasets and developed APIs to surface insights for non-technical research stakeholders, reducing latency by 41%. These projects map directly to your need for someone who can build and maintain the University DataCommons analytics platform, develop predictive models, and translate findings into actionable insights for Student Affairs teams.

I also bring experience building stakeholder-facing dashboards and visualizations that make complex findings accessible to non-technical audiences, along with a deep understanding of the rigor that research involving student behavioral and wellbeing data demands. Virginia Tech's mission, *Ut Prosim*, resonates with me. I would welcome the chance to contribute to a team using data to improve the lives of students.

Sincerely,

Malhar Gudekar

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